Dissertation Style Guide

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1 Introduction

This document summarises the requirements of the School of Computing concerning the general contents and layout of dissertations. It must be read in conjunction with other documentation describing the objectives, project schedule, deliverables and marking scheme of the particular project on which you are engaged. These guidelines closely follow the British Standard for the preparation of theses (BS 4821). Although aimed at students preparing dissertations, the formatting and stylistic sections of this document will also be helpful to those preparing smaller reports.

Remember that the quality of the dissertation itself is the component we attach most weight to in the marking scheme. Criteria that examiners use can be seen in the Marking Sheets for Supervisors and Internal examiners. This means that to do your practical work credit, you must be able to describe what you have done cogently, in written form.

There are four main aspects to the dissertation:

- layout and formatting;
- writing style including grammar, spelling, sentence structure, clarity, appropriate use of terms and terminology;
- organisation and structure of the dissertation;
- appropriateness and scope of content including quality of discussion.

This document contains all you need to know about layout and formatting. The best advice is to adopt the required layout standards early on, so that there is no major editing to be done later. Some advice is also given on writing style.

There should be no excuse for spelling mistakes: spelling checkers take care of most spelling errors. Grammar checking is also a feature of many modern word processors. If your grammar is very weak you may find them helpful. The main point is that these surface-level aspects of presentation are fairly readily dealt with by making use of writing tools. Structure, organisation, content, tone and argumentation are not so easily fixed. These are aspects of writing that most people have to work at.

If you find difficulty expressing what you want to say precisely and concisely the following suggestions should help:

- When you read, do so critically, looking not just at what the author is saying, but how he or she is crafting the writing;
- Read a variety of different computing sources (e.g. books, journal articles, weekly press, magazines) and examine the writing styles;
- Read your own work critically, refining it over several versions until it makes the impact that you want.

2 Expected contents

Normally, the contents of a dissertation will be as detailed in Table 1 below. The mandatory items are emboldened.

Title page
Submission checklist
Authorship declaration
Data protection declaration
Abstract
Contents list
List of tables
List of figures
Acknowledgements

Main body of dissertation including
Introduction and/or Background
Literature review / theory
Specification
Analysis
Design / modelling
Implementation
Evaluation (of deliverable)
Discussion/Appraisal of achievement
Suggestions for future work
References

Appendices (including such things as)

User manual Short examples of code Documents used or created (e.g. questionnaire) Relevant correspondence (e.g. appraisal by external client) Data collected **Evidence of project management** (diary, project work schedule (Gantt chart or similar))

Table 1: Expected contents of a dissertation.

The nature of an individual topic may call for variation in the naming and organisation of the main body of the document and in the contents of the appendices. It is undesirable therefore to be prescriptive about the sections this should contain.

The framework for individual dissertations should be agreed with Project Supervisors as early as is feasible. Students are strongly recommended to submit draft documents to their supervisors as they go along. Good academic writing is a skill that can be acquired, but supervisors can only help if work is forthcoming.

2.1 Title page

This should contain the following information:

- title of the work,
- full name of author,
- standard wording as shown in Figure 1 (substituting the title of your degree and including the name of any industrial or other collaborator as appropriate),
- month and year of submission.

THE USE OF MULTI-MEDIA
ON THE INTERNET

JOHN DOE

Submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements of
Edinburgh Napier University for the degree of
Master of Science in Computing

School of Computing
August 2019

Figure 2.1: Specimen title page.
(An actual title page should occupy one whole sheet of A4 and should have no border).

2.2 Submission checklist, Authorship declaration and Data Protection declaration

The dissertation is to start with the checklist, in which you reassure us that you have included all the elements needed in order to pass the module. It will also help us to find them within your document, so as to award appropriate credit.

It is mandatory to include a statement confirming that the document and the work presented in it are your own effort. If it is later found that parts of the text, of the software or any other deliverable have been plagiarised (copied from the work of others without attribution) or obtained from others and passed off as your own, the University will always take action. Depending on the severity of the offence, the penalty will range from revision of the mark awarded, through to a public retraction of the degree.

The required form can be downloaded from the forms section. You must sign and date the declaration and must include your Napier University Matriculation number. The declaration is thus made and signed by the person to whom the award will be made.

The next page of your dissertation is the Data Protection declaration. This is also available on the forms section and must be signed as well.

2.3 Abstract

The abstract should be not more than one page in length. It should allow a reader who is unfamiliar with the work to gain a swift and accurate impression of what the project is about, how it arose and what has been achieved. See Appendix 2 for advice on the writing of abstracts.

2.4 Contents list

The contents list should give a complete list of what the report contains starting with the authorship declaration (the title page is not included in the contents list). A specimen contents list is given in Table 2. This is provided for layout guidance and illustration only, the exact contents will differ substantially between projects. Likewise, the page numbers here are purely fictional.

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Table 2.1: Specimen table of contents.
(Note: an actual contents list does not have a border and may extend over more than one page.)

2.5 List of tables/figures

If the report contains figures or tables, a list of these should be provided. The list should give the table or figure number, the title of the table or figure and the page number. If only a few tables and figures are present, they may be treated on one page. Remember that all figures and tables used must be referred to in the text.

2.6 Acknowledgements

It is normal to thank those who have given help and support (typically your supervisor should get a kind mention!). Keep acknowledgements short and business-like, but do take care to remember all those who deserve credit. This is especially important where outside agencies are involved, or where experimental work has been carried out. Remember to include the names of proof-readers.

2.7 Introduction/background

This section introduces the reader to the subject area of the project. It may include, for example, how the need for the system was identified, the nature of the application area, the relationship with any industrial partner and so on. Where the project is interdisciplinary, this section should provide an introduction to contributing domains. Some evidence of reading around the subject area will be expected for all dissertations. The quality of the literature review and how knowledge gained from it fed into the work done are criteria examiners will be especially aware of in distinguishing average dissertations from first class ones.

2.8 Discussion

Whatever the organisation of the main body of the document, it is usual to have a rounding off section called *discussion, conclusion* or perhaps *evaluation of achievement.* This section can be used in different ways depending on the nature of the project. It may be used to draw together major themes into a summary and conclusion. It can be used to refer back to the specification to demonstrate that the objectives of the project have been met.

Another use is to highlight important findings and to suggest how these findings may have relevance in other sub-fields of a subject area, in other application areas or with different users. The discussion section will mention difficulties encountered too, perhaps limitations of the tools and techniques used - also aspects of the project that with hindsight you would have tackled differently. If appropriate, the final section should mention possibilities for future work based on the project.

Examiners will be looking not only for a high technical standard, but also for a well-developed critical sense demonstrated through self-evaluation of the work completed.

2.9 Appendices

Appendices should be used for reference material, such as selected pieces of program code and other information which would be too bulky, or would detract from the flow of the text, if included in the body of the document. You should be selective about what you include in the appendices. This is not the place to dump material such as a copy of every interview that you transcribed.

(For technical projects: Program listings

It is not necessary to include comprehensive program listings. We particularly discourage lengthy listings, especially where these include copious library routines that are not your own work. Use short extracts from the code for illustrative purposes in the main body of the text,

for example, to point out interesting features of the development language, innovative solutions to technical problems, and the quality of the code or of its documentation.

Longer extracts should be put in appendices, but only if there is good reason and you have referred to them in the document. Note that listings should be on A4 paper. They may be photo-reduced to conserve paper, but should have appropriate margins for binding.)

2.10 References

There should always be a list of all books, articles and technical sources consulted. With the exception of references such as programming language texts, which may not merit a citation in your document, the use of all other source materials should be explicit in the dissertation. This means that normally every item in the reference list will be cited (referred to) in the dissertation and every item mentioned in the dissertation will have an entry in the reference list.

Please use the instructions in the yellow referencing booklet to format the entries in your reference list.

3 Document format

The information in this section explains how the dissertation should look. It is far easier to absorb these standards, set them up on a word-processor and use them throughout the preparation of a document than to attempt a major rearrangement of material to conform with them at the last minute.

3.1 Length

The recommended target is 12000 – 20000 words, but there is no hard and fast rule about overall length. This will vary from project to project depending on the nature of the work tackled. Bear in mind, though, that external examiners favour concise reports with supporting material in appendices. Do seek advice in individual cases, and remember, quantity is no substitute for quality.

3.2 Paper

The entire document, including program listings, must be submitted on A4 size paper.

3.3 Margins

Left margin 3.81 cm (1.5"), right margin 2.54cm (1"), top and bottom margins 2.54cm (1").

3.4 Justification

Right and left margins should be justified (giving a straight edge to the text on both sides).

3.5 Font style and size

Use a Times Roman, Arial or similar style font, point size 12 for most of the document. Some people find Arial fonts easier to read than Times Roman. Since you will be spending a large

amount of time proof reading your own work, you might want to test whether Arial or Times Roman is better for you.

Any code extracts should be produced in a point size of about 10 to reduce bulk. This can be done by importing them into a word-processor or by photo-reducing. Print quality must be good.

3.6 Pagination

The report must carry sequential pagination throughout, including appendices. Use Arabic numerals (1, 2, 3 etc.). The page number should be at the top right margin of each page.

3.7 Page breaks

Try to ensure that page breaks occur in sensible places. Take a new page for each main section. There is no need to take a new page for sub-section headings, but make sure that at least a couple of lines of text follow a heading, otherwise insert a page break before the heading. Never let a page break separate the last line of a paragraph. (In Microsoft Word, page breaks are created using control-enter).

3.8 Header

In addition to the page number, the document header should include the candidate's name, qualification sought and calendar year, e.g. J. DOE, MSc Information Systems, 2008.

3.9 Footnotes

Footnotes are optional. If used, they must be sequentially numbered throughout the document. They can be a convenient way to include an explanatory note that may be needed by some readers, but not by others. In general, avoid them unless including the point you want to make would seriously detract from the flow of the text.

3.10 Paragraphs

These should be blocked (no indentation on the first line) and separated by a single blank line.

3.11 Citations

Where it is necessary to quote a sizeable chunk (around 30 words or more) from the work of another author, the quotation should be blocked and indented 1.27cm (0.5") from the left and right margin, it should also be separated from the preceding and following text by blank lines. There is no need to use quotation marks.
If this was an extract from a publication about report-writing that I wanted to include, it would be set off in this way to distinguish it from my own words. When quoting direct from a source, it is essential to provide a full citation, including page number, so that readers can locate the passage if they so desire. (Bloggs, 1993, p. 9).
Bloggs (1993) would appear in the references. If the quotation spans more than one published page, the form is (Bloggs, 1993, pp. 9-10). If the quotation omits some material between the source's start and end points, this is indicated by three dots as follows:

If this were an extract from a book ... it would be set off in this way to distinguish it from my own words. When quoting ... provide a full reference, including page number, so that readers can locate the passage if they so desire. (Bloggs, 1993, p. 9).
When quoting smaller amounts, the quotation can be incorporated in the text, without the need to offset it. In this case quotation marks are used to delineate the words copied. For example, according to Bloggs and Jones (1982) "it is of paramount importance to acknowledge the work of others and to avoid the charge of plagiarism". Where there are two or more items in the reference list by the same author(s) and published in the same year, it is the convention to call the first source cited a and the second b and so forth. Naturally, the a and b are also added to the publication dates in the reference list. For example, according to Bloggs and Jones (1982a) "it is of paramount importance to acknowledge the work of others and to avoid the charge of plagiarism".

A further way to cite the work of others is to refer to it, but not quote from it. The next sentence gives an example. According to Bloggs (1991) the use of formal methods has little to offer the developer of large-scale systems, however, recent work by Brown and colleagues (Brown, Jones and Green, 1999) suggests that tools are emerging that make the adoption of formal methods in industry a viable prospect.

By far the best way of using published work is for you to make the statement yourself, and then add a citation to another work which agrees with your statement. Thus the example of the previous paragraph might be written as: "The use of formal methods has little to offer the developer of large scale systems (Bloggs, 1991). However, recently published work suggests that tools are emerging that make the adoption of formal methods in industry a viable prospect (Brown, Jones and Green, 1999)." The result is that your literature review moves from being a collection of other peoples' quotes to become a chapter in which you are telling the narrative in your own words, backed up by citations to give it authority.

Having referred to Brown, Jones and Green in full on the first mention of their 1999 publication, they can be referred to on subsequent occasions as Brown et al., (1999).

Care in acknowledging the work of others is of paramount importance in all areas of life, but especially in academic work, where the currency is not physical objects, but ideas. Use of the work of others without attribution is tantamount to stealing.

In presenting work for examination it is necessary to be diligent in this respect for three main reasons; firstly to furnish evidence of literature read, secondly to establish the body of work from which your own arises (a piece of work for which no related literature exists will be rightly regarded with suspicion) and thirdly, to be able to demonstrate the aspects of your work that are novel and for which you should properly take credit.

3.12 Line spacing

The text of the document should be 1½ spaced.

3.13 Headings and legends

Section and subsection headings should be emboldened. Major headings should be printed in point size 14. Legends (these are the figure and table identifications) should be emboldened and centred, but not enlarged. Other explanatory text should be in point size 10.

3.14 Sectioning

Sections and subsections are used to organise the document into cohesive chunks for the reader. Give them meaningful headings. If the contents page shows repeated page numbers (several subsections beginning on the same page), this is a sure sign that the document is too bitty and that your subsections are too short. In this case, collapse them into a larger unit. Note that there is a point ('.') between subsection numbers, but not after the last. So '3.1.2' is right and '3.1.2.' is wrong.

3.15 Tables and figures

Tables and figures should each be sequentially (and separately) numbered throughout the chapter. Thus the first table in chapter 3 will be Table 3.1. The first figure in chapter 3 will be Figure 3.1. They should be centred and labelled with an identification number and title (as in this document). The identification number and title (i.e. the caption) should come directly under the figure or table. What the table or figure is intended to show should be clear.

If a graphical representation is used, axes must be clearly labelled. It is common to include a line or two under the table identifier to clarify the contents. If it is necessary to fit the contents of a table onto one page, 10 point font size may be used. Alternatively the page may be printed in landscape mode. Make sure that the exact wording of the legends (table or figure titles) appears in the list of figures and tables.

Note that when you refer to a particular figure or table in the dissertation, the initial letter of the word 'figure' or 'table' should always be capitalised.

3.16 Appendices

These should be sequentially numbered starting with Appendix 1. Sequential pagination continues from the main body of the document through the appendices.

3.17 References

Please see the Guidelines for Referencing and the Use of Turnitin.

4 Stylistic and grammatical advice

4.1 Apostrophes

One of the commonest mistakes in students' writing is incorrect use of the apostrophe ('). The apostrophe is tricky, but the advice below should help. It is used in English to form contractions such as didn't (did not), can't (cannot) and it's (it is). These uses should be avoided in academic writing and the words written out in full. Note especially, that the possessive form of the pronoun *it* is *its,* <u>not</u> it's. So *the dog licked its paw* is right, whereas *the dog licked it's paw* is wrong.

The apostrophe is also used to denote possessive case, as in *the dog's bone* or *the student's assignment.* The rule here is that if the intended noun is singular (one dog) the apostrophe is placed before the *s.* The examples above refer to a single dog and a single student

respectively. If the intended noun is plural and regularly formed, the apostrophe is placed after the *s* as in *dogs'* (of the dogs).

However, if the noun has an irregular plural, e.g. child -> children, the apostrophe is placed before the *s* as in *children's* (of the children). Table 3 should help to clarify the situation, at least for simple cases.

Note that an apostrophe is not needed when forming the possessive of pronouns such as his, hers, ours or theirs. An exception to this is *one's.*

The student's report.	One report authored by one student.
The students' report.	One report authored by more than one student.
The student's reports.	Two or more reports authored by the same student.
The students' reports.	Here we know that there is more than one student and more than one report, but from grammar alone cannot tell what the mapping is between report and student.

Table 3: Correct use of the apostrophe.

4.2 Acronyms

Your dissertation work is completed in a field in which acronyms are heavily used to avoid repetition of long technical terms, e.g. RAM, VDU, LAN, RISC. Terms like PC are now so commonly used by the population at large that it is rapidly becoming admissible to use them without explanation. However, most acronyms are familiar only to specialists within sub-fields of the domain. When using an acronym for the first time, always precede it with the expanded version. For example, a first-in first-out (FIFO) buffer is sometimes used to delay a signal.

4.3 Colloquialisms

Colloquialisms are chatty, idiomatic or slang expressions that are appropriate in informal conversation, but have no place in academic writing. For example, *avoid* referring to a piece of hardware as a 'bog standard PC'. Likewise *avoid writing like this:*
Once Mr x pulled his finger out, the team started to come together better and eventually we managed to hand something in that was pretty reasonable considering we didn't know each other much before this option. (This is a barely edited excerpt from work that has been submitted in the School of Computing!).
A related point is that in academic and technical writing the use of the first person (I) is avoided as much as possible. In similar vein, avoid referring to the reader as 'you'.

The following quotation is the unaltered work of a first year computing student. It illustrates a poor style of technical writing and one which certainly would have irritated the examiner. The underlining has been introduced to emphasise the parts to note.

It would take a lot more than a few thousand words to explain about Computer Aided Engineering so I have basically concentrated on Computer Aided Manufacturing with the use of Numerical Control and Robotics. From time to time I will try to give you a brief history of the developments in CAM technology and at the end of this Report there will be a brief insight into what we can expect in the future. Hopefully you will gain some knowledge from this report and realise the importance that computers will play in Industry. There are many people who think that computers will only bring damage but it has become essential in a highly competitive market that companies make use of the available technology. Whether you think they are good or bad, you cannot deny that they are here to stay.

4.4 Grammar

Do be careful to write in fully formed sentences, and to proof read the document to ensure, not only that the text is grammatically sound, but also that it means exactly what was intended.

4.5 Jargon

Try to strike a good balance between use of jargon for jargon's sake and appropriate use of technical terms. There is no merit in using so much obscure terminology that the document is virtually unreadable, however, failure to utilise keywords properly can lead to unnecessary verbosity and tends to give an unprofessional impression. It is important to be consistent in the use of terms, to define them if necessary, and to use the same term for the same concept throughout your work. For example, do not refer *to time frames, time slots and time intervals* if they all mean the same thing: select one of these terms and tell the reader on first usage exactly what is meant by it.

4.6 Spelling

There should be no excuse for spelling mistakes in a word-processed document. Spelling errors create a very bad impression. Always use a spelling checker, they are invaluable for picking up typographical errors as well as genuine spelling mistakes.

Note, however, that spelling checkers cannot detect cases where the wrong word happens to be a real word, (for example, *from* as a mis-typing of *form*), so there is no escaping the need for careful proof reading.

It is well worthwhile building up a project dictionary if the subject of study contains many uncommon terms. Be consistent in the spelling of words with optional endings such as *ise* and *ize* and in the spelling of words with optional forms, such as *disc* and *disk.*

4.7 Developing an argument

One of the main difficulties seen in students' writing is the inability to develop an argument. Developing an argument means writing a set of paragraphs which are logically ordered, and which progress a line of reasoning or a line of enquiry. Too often students have this argument in their heads, but write in disconnected fragments, expecting the reader to fill in the holes.

Academic writing is not like fiction, where understatement can be an effective device. It is more like Law, where a case must be seen to be proven, step by step. Often, all that is

missing are the appropriate links between sentences and paragraphs to show how they fit together.

This idea of cohesion is as important in presenting a literature review as in presenting new ideas. A common mistake is to survey related work, but to provide no critical commentary on the findings. So the reader is left with an undigested catalogue of citations, with no guidance as to what this all amounts to, or how it has given rise to the project topic.

A good way to learn about critically reviewing literature is to read journal papers. A major journal paper will always refer to relevant literature, pointing out how the work in hand extends previous published findings, utilises previous work in novel ways, or perhaps contradicts previous findings.

5 Organisational hints

This section offers a few pointers that should make writing up a project less burdensome.

Write in full paragraphs, not in short note form. This means organising the material systematically. The paragraphs should be ordered logically so that they lead the reader through the report in a sensible way. Each paragraph should have a purpose in developing your line of argument.

For every paragraph it should be possible to say what its purpose is, why it is placed where it is and why it contains what it does. This may seem a rather tall order, but imposing a structured and analytical approach to writing English increases its productivity and readability. Imagine the effects on a reader of a report where bits of the introductory material are scattered around the document and the achievements are mixed in with implementation details. It is rather like a recipe that contains all the necessary instructions, but in the wrong order.

5.1 Use of tools

Many students make the mistake of sitting down at the end of a project's life cycle to the arduous task of 'typing up' the dissertation. A much better way is to set up the framework for the document early on. In a PC environment it is advisable to create a separate file for each major section for the following reasons:

- Because large documents containing tables or graphics can be slow to scroll through and cause other unnecessary processing overheads.
- If disaster strikes losses will be contained.
- It can be easier to take advantage of multi-windowing (having more than one part of the document visible simultaneously).

Start off by writing the framework of your section as a series of section headings. Text can be added underneath the headings later. If the framework of a document is in place early, notes can be made in the sections yet to be written as ideas occur. Likewise, notes should always be made of early reading. Inevitably something read early on and discarded will turn out to be crucial later - large amounts of wasted time are then expended trying to recall where the item was seen and searching for it.

A good plan, which will save time in the long run, is to create a bibliography file, in the format suggested here, and enter into it everything consulted. This is the start of a valuable personal bibliography, from which the eventual reference list can be created by cutting and pasting. Double-checking all details in the bibliography file on first entry eliminates errors - thereafter one should never need to re-type, always cut and paste. If you don't do this, there is a risk that you will need to find the work twice - once to consult it for information and then a second time to check its reference.

The principle of minimising typing is important. For example, when creating a new figure or table, paste the legend straight into the list of figures or list of tables as you create it in the main document. Likewise, every time an author is cited, check the references and enter the details if they do not already exist. Working in an incremental way like this, with two or three files open simultaneously, significantly reduces workload and minimises the chance of errors.

Finally, a word processor allows the author to refine and re-organise text very easily. A first draft should be regarded as a rough approximation, to be honed into shape. By writing throughout the project's development and not in one mighty rush at the end, there is plenty of time to reflect on the shape of the document and to return to earlier parts with a fresh eye. Sometimes it can be difficult to convey technical ideas succinctly - in this case, circulating a troublesome part to peers for feedback can be helpful. Finally, for those who get stuck for words, or find themselves confused about the meanings of close pairs such as *personal/personnel* and *effect/affect,* words can be checked using a thesaurus or dictionary of a word processor or with the help of an on-line search engine.

Appendix 1: Avoiding sexism in academic writing

Unfortunately, English has no neuter pronoun that can be used to refer to a singular person whose gender is unknown. The convention has been to use 'he' in these cases (in the same way that 'man' has been used to refer to people in general).

Recently, with increased awareness of the potentially damaging effects of this masculine bias in the language, efforts have been made to eradicate inappropriate use of masculine (and feminine) pronouns and to introduce neuter versions of offending words - chairman/chairperson. Authors often add a footnote to the effect that 'he' is used to mean 'he or she' and that no prejudice is intended. However, some universities and publishing houses no longer accept this sort of disclaimer and will not tolerate what is seen as sexist writing. Note that using 'she' throughout instead of 'he' is equally discriminatory and therefore no better than using 'he'.

The School of Computing recommends that all documents issuing from the department (letters, theses, internal reports, lecture notes) be free of sexism. This can be done by following the points below. It is generally possible to 'neutralise' any sentence without the text becoming contorted or stilted.

1. When referring to an individual whose gender *is* known, use 'he/his' or 'she/her' as appropriate.

2. When referring to an individual whose gender is unknown avoid committing to 'he' or 'she'. This can be done by re-phrasing or by pluralising.

Examples of re-phrasing

☹ Once a manager is satisfied that procedures have been carried out, he may...
☺ Once satisfied that procedures have been carried out, a manager may ...

☹ Authority to modify software rests with the senior programmer; he is answerable to the section manager.
☺ Authority to modify software rests with the senior programmer who is answerable to the section manager.

☹ If he thinks it necessary, the instructor should repeat these questions at the beginning of the next session.
☺ If it seems necessary, the instructor should repeat these questions at the beginning of the next session.

Examples of pluralising

☹ The user should start by booting his machine.
☺ Users should start by booting their machines.

☹ Once a student is competent with the editor he should be able to operate any other editor with very little training, thus the skills are transferable.
☺ Once students are competent with the editor they should be able to operate any other editor with very little training, thus the skills are transferable.

Appendix 2: Writing a good abstract

Too often, the abstract is dashed off at the last minute, without fully appreciating how important this short summary is in conveying an impression of achievement to examiners. In academic life the abstract plays an important role.

The first stage in submitting a paper to a conference is often to submit an abstract of the work, the abstracts are refereed and on the basis of this 'selection by abstract', some of the authors are invited to produce a full paper. Every published paper is preceded by an abstract; readers decide which papers to study in detail by skimming the abstracts. Likewise, when literature searching, one has to decide on the basis of the abstract, whether that paper is important to read or not.

In business, too, the technique of writing succinct summaries is a valuable skill. Producing briefings, summarising recommendations, making a business case and formulating procedures are all activities where a small quantity of crisp, clear writing is advantageous.

For the purposes of the dissertation, the abstract should contain a clear statement of what the project is about, what the scope of the work is, what has been achieved and what the most important features of the work are.

An introduction to a piece of creative writing, may encourage the reader to read more by promising information which will be supplied by the main body of the story. This tantalising

ploy of arousing interest but not giving too much away works well in literature of this style. On the other hand, a good abstract deliberately ruins all surprises by satisfying all curiosity.

After reading the abstract, an examiner should be in no doubt:

- That the general aims of the project have been met.
- About the scope, technical difficulty and distinguishing characteristics of the particular project.